

Shoftim VeShotrim Titen Lecho

Maamor — free translation & elucidation · Shabbos Parshas Shoftim, Elul 5729 · bilti-mugah

MAAMOR

The hand of the witnesses

The Possuk states:

יד ה' ע (17:7) ה' יד
 דים תהי' בו בראשנה לה
 מיתו ויד כל' העם באחר
 נה ובערת' הרע מקרב

שפטים ושטרם תתן-לך בכלי-שעריך אשר יהוה אלהיך נתן לך לשבטיך ושפטו
 את-העם משפט-צדק

**ו' "You shall set up judges and enforcement officers [see footnote] for yourself
 in all your cities etc and finishes with the words: "**

Finishes: The section dealing with laws that are relevant and associated with judges and enforcement officers.

CONCEPT

Possuk: (16:18) ש פ טים ו ש טרים ת תן-לך ב כל-ש ע ריך א ש ר ה' א ל קיך נ תן לך ל ש ב
 You shall set up judges and law enforcement officials for
 yourself in all your gates (cities) that HaShem, your G-d, is giving you, for your tribes, and they
 shall judge the people with righteous judgment". Rashi says on the words: "Judges and law-
 enforcement officials" ש פ טים are judges who decide the verdict, and ש טרים are those who
 chastise the people in compliance with their order, or who strike and bind with rods and straps,
 until the guilty party accepts the judge's verdict.

ו בערת הרע מקרבך

you shall abolish evil from within you

ו בערת הרע מישראל

: And you shall abolish evil from Yisroel".

All this corresponds [analogously] to that which our Chachomim of blessed memory expound on the words shall be first upon him to put him to death, and afterwards the hand of all the people, and you shall abolish evil from among you”

of a Possuk: “ קטנה עיר small city” refers to the human body. “

ואנשים בה מעט

“The people are few”

Big: The Yetzer Hora is called ‘big’ because it is thirteen years older than the Yetzer Tov which only enters one’s body at his Bar Mitzvah whereas the Yetzer Hora is there from birth (Koheles Rabbah 9:15).

refer to the limbs of one’s body. “

Evil inclination: That lives inside the human.

Works against it: This is the work of the Yetzer Hora. Setting ambushes and traps to take and maintain control of the person causing him to stumble and sin.

ואבא לי ה מ לך גד

“A Big King came”

King: The Yetzer Hora is called a king because everyone listens to him (Koheles Rabbah 4:13).

this refers to the Yetzer Hora, the evil inclination.⁹ “

וסבב אתה ובה עליה מצ

I

דים גדלים

And he surrounded it and built mighty siege works against it”¹⁰ about which it stated:

שפטים ושרים תתן לך בכל שער ריך

“You shall set up judges and enforcement officers for

built great bulwarks against it,” these are sins. “Now there was found in it a man poor and wise,” refers to the good inclination; “and he by his wisdom delivered the city,” refers to repentance and good deeds that are caused by the good inclination. “Yet no man remembered that same poor man” means that when the evil inclination overcomes the good inclination no one remembers the good inclination. (This is also brought down in the Medrash Koheles Rabbah 9:15). 6 Possuk: Koheles (9:14)

עיר קטנה ואנשים בה מעט ובא אליה מלך גדול וסבב אתה

[“

ובנה עליה מצודים גדולים

There was] a small city, with few people in it, and a great king came upon it and surrounded it and built mighty siege works against it.”

(9:15)

ומצא בה איש מסכן כן חסדו מלך הוא אתה עיר בה כח מתו ואדם

“

לא זכר אתה האיש המסכן ההוא

And there was found therein a poor wise man, and he extricated the city through his wisdom, but no man remembered that poor man”

3

yourself at all your gates” meaning that each and every person must place “judges and enforcement officers” at all the ‘gates’ of the human body which is the ‘small city’. 11 The purpose of this Avodah, 12 is to effectuate that which the Possuk says: “

you shall abolish evil from within you”, which refers to the Yetzer hora, as our Rabbis of blessed memory have stated in the Talmud

Small city: To prevent the Yetzer Hora from taking control.

51:12); by inference, there is an impure heart that is the evil inclination. 4. Shlomoh called it אֹיֵב ‘enemy’, as it is stated: “If your enemy is hungry, give him bread to eat, and if he is thirsty, give him water to drink; for you will heap coals of fire upon his head, and HaShem will reward you” (Mishlei 25:21–22). Do not read it as: And HaShem will reward you; rather read it as: And HaShem will reconcile it to you. HaShem will cause the evil inclination to love you and no longer seek to entice you to sin. 5. Yeshaya called it a ‘שֹׁכֵל’ stumbling block’, as it is stated: “And He will say: Cast you up, cast you up, clear the way, take up the stumbling block out of the way of 4

Within you: In other words, abolish the Yetzer Hora that is within you.

that there are seven names by which the evil inclination is called, and Hakodosh Boruch Hu calls the Yetzer Hora ‘Rah’ - evil, and this is the inference of the Possuk “you shall abolish evil from within you”.¹⁴ As a result of [this Avodah whereby] he “drives out evil from within” it effectuates the Possuk “abolish evil from Yisroel”, that he [in the process] drives out the evil from the general populace of Yisroel and [further] from the entire world. [This is akin to what the Rambam writes: That a person My people” (Yeshaya 57:14). 6. Yechezkal called it ‘אֶבֶן’ a stone’, as it is stated: “And I will take away the stony heart out of your flesh, and I will give you a heart of flesh” (Yechezkal 36:26). 7. Yoel called it ‘צִפּוֹנִי’ hidden one’, as it says: “But I will remove the northern one Hatzefoni far off from you” (Yoel 2:20). The Sages of blessed memory taught concerning the verse: “But I will remove the northern one ‘Hatzefoni’ far off from you,” that this is referring to the evil inclination. And why is the evil inclination referred to as Tzefoni? It is due to the fact that it is always hidden - Tzofun in one’s heart. 5

For since: The reason why this is possible that because someone eradicated his own evil and then eradicate all of the B’nei Yisroel’s evil he can then eradicate evil from the entire world is because...

has to visualise himself and also the entire world in perfect balance [so] that everyone is exactly [one] half meritorious and [one] half culpable. This means that by performing one solitary Mitzvah, a person tips the scales for himself and the entire world to a majority of good deeds].¹⁶ For, since the world was created for Yisroel, as our sages have expounded on the Possuk in Bereishis,¹⁸ “For cause of its destruction; but if he perform one duty, behold, he will overbalance himself and the whole world to the side of virtue, and bring about his own and their salvation and escape, even as it is said: “But the righteous is an everlasting foundation” (Prov. 10. 25), it is he, by whose righteousness he overbalanced the whole world

From Yisroel: Who are the raison d'être - the intended purpose of the entire creation.

to virtue and saved it.” 16 Good deeds: This is how we are able to understand how a single person’s solitary act can affect the entire world. Similarly, as a result of a single person doing a solitary act of self-nullification nullifying and eradicating his own evil inclination he can affect an eradication and nullification of evil in general throughout the entire world. 6

Yisroel who are called Reishis”,¹⁹ as a result of that [avodah] the evil becomes eradicated from Yisroel,²⁰ [and consequently] automatically the evil becomes eradicated from the entire world. And all this comes about through

ש פ ט ים ו ש ט ר ים

‘Judges and Officers’.

CONCEPT

Called Reishis: (Yirmiyohu 2:3) ק ד ש י ש ר א ל ה' ר א ש י ת ת ב ו א ת ה כ ל- א כ ל י ו י א ש מ ו
Yisroel is holy to HaShem, the first of His grain; all who eat him shall be guilty, evil shall befall them, says HaShem.”

Because the ‘Judges’²² relates to that which our Rabbis of blessed memory have said: 23 Sages have said: Talmud Brochos (5a) One should always incite his good inclination against his evil inclination, i.e., that one must constantly struggle so that his evil inclination does not lead him to transgression. If one succeeds and subdues his evil inclination, excellent, but if he does not succeed in subduing it, he should study Torah, as alluded to in the verse: (Tehilim 4:5)

ר ג ז ו ו א ל- ת ח ט א ו א מ ר ו ב ל ב ב כ מ ע ל- מ ש כ ב כ מ ו ד מ ו ס ל ה

with the words: “Say to your heart.”

If he subdues his evil inclination, excellent; if not, he should recite Shema, which contains the acceptance of the yoke of heaven, and the concept of reward and punishment, as it is stated in the verse: “Upon your bed,” which 7

insist... over his evil inclination. As Rashi explains he should wage war with his evil inclination. The animal soul and the evil inclination are born with the body and being that the good inclination with the Neshomo only fully enter the body at the Bar Mitzvah the animal soul and the evil inclination presume that they have rights and therefore if one were not to incite his good inclination over his evil inclination and be worried about upsetting the status quo he would never achieve his full potential and would always choose hedonism over achievement.

“One should always incite his good inclination over his evil inclination”.²⁴ ‘Officers’ is as our Rabbis of blessed memory have said:²⁵ “One should bring to mind the day of his death” (which is akin to an officer meting out a punishment). And even though the reminder of punishment (Officers) alludes to Shema, where it says: “When you lie down.” If he subdues his evil inclination, excellent; if not, he should remind himself of the day of death, whose silence is alluded to in the continuation of the verse: “And be still, Selah.”.

Rabbis... have said: In the continuation of our abovementioned

quote, in Talmud, Tractate Berachot 5A it says: “So said Rabbi Levi the son of Chama in the name of Rabbi Shimon son of Lakish-‘A person should constantly anger his Yetzer Hara with his Yetzer Tov as the Possuk says “They became angry and they didn’t sin” meaning, if you are victorious in this service, then good, and if not then you should toil in Torah study...” The Talmud goes on to say other rectifications for things you aren’t able to do until it says, “And if you can’t read the Shema, you should remind himself of the day of his death...”. Which: This action of remembering one’s day of death to come, helps one to be victorious against the Yetzer Hora and this triumph is because of one’s fear of punishment or fear of dying and meeting one’s creator with a stained soul is akin to fearing the punishment of the enforcement officer. 8

Goal: To win over the evil inclination.

will surely achieve its intended goal,²⁷ whereas the incitement of the good inclination over the evil inclination (Judges) may not succeed every time,²⁸ as is apparent from the continuation of the Rabbis statement when they say that a person should always (Initially) incite his good inclination over his evil inclination, and if that succeeds then well and good, but if it does not succeed then ...a person should bring to mind the day of his death.” ²⁹ Nevertheless, the order of one’s Avodah needs to be that, first he must incite his good inclination over his evil don’t expect it to succeed every time. ³⁰ Order: The Right hand which is the stronger hand and traditionally always the first to encourage as the Talmud states in Sotah (47a) It should always be the left, weaker, hand that pushes another away but the right, stronger, hand should draw him near. One of our tasks in this world is to sweeten the Divine Gevuros with Divine Chessed. i.e. the regular order. 9

לזכות אילנה רפאילה בת שרה לרפואה שלימה וקרובה

inclination ('Judges)³¹ and only thereafter if that does not achieve its intended goal,³² does he need to carry out the Avodah of reminding oneself of the day of death ('Officers).³³ contemplating about the day of his death and meeting his creator and this Avodah, will definitely achieve his goal. 10

Boruch Hu, whom no mind can grasp at all,³⁸ [yet] nevertheless, deeper understanding. understand. As the Zohar (1.103a) writes: Most certainly

נו דע ב ש ערים ב ע לה

that Hakodosh Boruch Hu is known and connected to each person according to his own assessment in his heart, each one according to how much he can connect to the spirit of wisdom and according to how much he is able to estimate in his heart that is how much his heart will know.

11

CONCEPT

Nevertheless: Even though all souls come from one entity and are therefore one entity there are differences, as the Alter Rebbe describes in Tanya how some Neshomos come from Odom's head and others from his toes and all in between, so as much as all souls are the same there are varied differences, and this is because there are varied differences in each soul's mission on this earth. Each soul has a different task and different place on this world to rectify. So, this is the word 'Shiuroh' from the word Sheorim that each one to his own appropriate mission.

Body of Neshomos: Which are in essence one entity.

because, even though all Neshomos are interrelated and 'We are all as one',⁴⁴ nevertheless the general body of Neshomos is divided into six hundred thousand individual root Neshomos, and each root Neshomah sub divides again into six hundred thousand sparks.⁴⁷ way in accordance with his own spiritual standing. 44 As one: All Neshomos of Yisroel are truly one entity, as the Talmud states: (Yevomos 62A/Niddah 13B) (Moshiach) The son of Dovid, will not come until all the souls of the body have been finished. Highlighting that they all belong to one body. Or as the Alter Rebbe explains in Tanya how all Neshomos today come from the Neshomo of Odom HoRishon. Or in Tanya (chapter 32) the Alter Rebbe writes: They (Neshomohs) are actually all equal; and not only equal yet separate, but, furthermore, they all have one father - one source, and within their source they all comprise one entity. It is on account of this common root in the One G-d that all of Yisroel are called "brothers" - in the full sense of the word, and not only figuratively, in the sense of "relatives" or "similar in appearance" and the like only the bodies are distinct from each other. 12

CONCEPT

Avodah Requirement: In Hayom Yom the Rebbe writes the Friediker Rebbes teachings and for the 3rd of Elul writes: “Whoever has faith in individual Divine Providence knows that (Tehillim 37:23.)”Man’s steps are established by HaShem,” that this particular soul must purify and improve something specific in a particular place. For centuries, or even since the world’s creation, that which needs purification or improvement waits for this particular soul to come and purify or improve it. The soul too, has been waiting - ever since it came into being - for its time to descend, so that it can discharge the tasks of purification and improvement assigned to it.”

Therefore, no two Neshomoh sparks have the same Avodah requirement,⁴⁸ as in the Avodah of Reuven is serving HaShem through vision,⁵⁰ whereas the Avodah world as a whole, since the world was created for the sake of these souls. Each specific one of them contains and to each is related the vitality of one six-hundred-thousandth-part of the entire world. This part of the world depends on his vital soul for its elevation to HaShem through the vital soul’s own elevation. This means that one elevates “his” portion of the world by his partaking of this world for the requirements of his body and vital soul in the service of HaShem. By using the objects of this world that one’s body and vital soul need for the sake of serving HaShem, one elevates his portion of the world. ... But surely there are more than six hundred thousand souls; besides, it is quite impossible for one person to use a six-hundredthousandth of the entire world. These six hundred thousand individual souls, however, are “roots”; and, like a root from which grow numerous branches, each root-soul subdivides into six hundred thousand sparks, each spark being one Neshomoh. Similarly, with the Nefesh and Ruach, in each of the four Worlds of Atzilus, Beriah, Yetzirah and Asiyah. In each of these four Worlds are found all three soul-levels Nefesh, Ruach and Neshomoh. Each spark did not descend into this world to perfect itself but to perfect the body and vital soul. 13

of Shimon is through listening.⁵² The Avodah of Levi is the concept

ה פ ע ם י ל ו ה א י ש י א ל י

- **“My husband will be attached to me”⁵⁴ as is explained in Torah Ohr in the**

Listening: To serve HaShem through listening as the Possuk says (Devorim 6:4) ש מ ע י ש ר א ל “Hear Yisroel: HaShem is our G-d; HaShem is one” In the Talmud,

CONCEPT

Shimon: Named so by his mother Leah for its meaning that Hashem heard her call as the Possuk (Bereishis 29:33) testifies: ו ת ה ר ע ו ד ו ת ל ד ב נ ו ת א מ ר כ י ש מ ע ה כ י ש נ ו א ה א נ כ י ו י “And she conceived again and bore a son, and she said, “Since Hashem has heard that I am hated, He gave me this one too.” So, she named him Shimon”.

by heart, as in the translation of the words ‘Krias Shema’ meaning to read the Shema, to follow the reader in ‘Krias Hatorah’ reading in a Chumash. Only allowing kosher images and kosher writings to pass through one’s eyes. To be careful about taking a second look at something that caught one’s eye as the Possuk states (Bamidbar 15:39)

ולא תתורו אחר לבבכם ואחר עיניכם אשר – “אם תזנים אחר ריכם

You shall not wander after your hearts and after your eyes after which you are going astray”

which would include all the attractions of today more than ever before. Also, not looking at what someone else has and not being jealous or envious. All this and more is serving Hashem with one’s vision. Tractate Rosh Hashanah 26A, it says, “One cannot compare the superior level of vision to that of hearing”, Moshe wanted us all to serve HaShem through seeing, with a vivid clarity as if one was actually seeing HaShem right in front of him. But it was not to be in the normal manner for HaShem allowed us only to connect through hearing which from this Talmud would seem inferior to that of Reuven’s service of HaShem through seeing. However, on the upside serving Hashem when one has the absolute clarity of the Divine reality is hardly as impressive as someone who serves HaShem from a perspective of hearing where he does not have the clarity but from absolute faith. 14

Parsha of Vayechi.⁵⁵ This explanation of the word שׁ ע רים which refers to an individual Avodah ‘each one according to his own ability’⁵⁶ is connected with the second explanation of the word שׁ ע רים. 2. The second [of these two] explanations of the word שׁ ע רים comes from the word

Second explanation: Sha’arim in this context also comes from the same word as ‘Shiur’ but this time meaning a fixed measure, a predetermined size, a limited quantity.

שיעור וגבול

meaning measurement and limitation, which refers to the Avodah of each individual,⁵⁸ even someone who already serves HaShem at a level of infinity without constraints

Own ability: Sha’arim in this context comes from the same word as ‘Shiur’ or ‘LeSha’er’ meaning to estimate one’s own measured level, one’s cognitive ability, one’s grasp of spirituality and G-dliness, pertaining to him on his measured level.

absorbed in HaShem’s greatness. ⁵⁵ Torah Ohr Vayechi: Where it explains the specifics and details of the unique Avodah of someone with the name Reuven, that through vision one draws closer to HaShem in love. Shimon is the Avodah of ‘Shoiv’ of return and serving HaShem from a distance in fear. Levi is embracing HaShem and drawing HaShem down here through the Torah from high up above. And so on with the rest of the names of tribes, each one’s individual, personal, special Avoda that is predominant in them. The above serves to

highlight how everyone of the B'nei Yisroel has a unique Avodah to serve HaShem in his or her own special way that is individually unique to them. 15

CONCEPT

And you shall love HaShem your G-d with all your heart and with all your soul, and with all your means” Rashi translates Bechol Levovcho as both of your inclinations, your yetzer Tov and your Yetzer hora. Uvechol Nafshecho Rashi explains until your demise giving up your life. So, what is the meaning of Uvechol Me'odecho? What more can you possibly give HaShem? Since you already love Hashem with both your inclinations and are ready to die for Hashem. So, in Chassidus it is explained that Bechol Meodecho is giving beyond your normal limited capacity, serving HaShem whilst breaking out of the mold and loving HaShem with powers you did not even know that you have, giving what you don't yet have, giving your potential etc your limitless.

or limitation. Nevertheless, in comparison to HaShem,⁶¹ his service is very much limited, and how much more so with regards to someone who has not yet broken out of his own limitation.⁶² Nevertheless, ‘Her husband is known at the gates’- commanded to serve HaShem on three levels.

ו א ה ב ת א ת ה' א ל ק יך ב כ ל- ל ב בך “ ו ב כ ל- נ פ שך ו ב כ ל- מ א ד

his exist and have total obedience to HaShem's Supreme Will, the Torah. Hence, without his bodily limitations, the level of absolute infinite. 16

Hakodosh Boruch Hu makes himself known to all according to their own ability. 63 63 Known ... Own ability: Because HaShem recognises and understands (and therefore reveals Himself to) everyone according to their individual level, to the extent of one's individual capability to grasp and comprehend G-dliness. 64 Gates: According to the deeper understanding of what this Possuk represents. That a person shall have an understanding and grasp in G-dliness. (According to both explanations of according to his measurement and according to his limitation). 17

scent and speech. One's Avodah through his faculty of vision should be as the Possuk: ש א ו מ ר ו

Auditory faculty: The ability to hear

Listen: An understanding and

Vision: Meaning using one's vision to serve HaShem, as explained in earlier footnotes.

CONCEPT

Possuk: Yishayahu (40:26). שאור מרום עיני כם וראו מי ברא אלה המוציא במספר צב. "איש לא נעדר Lift up your eyes on high and see, who created these, who takes out their host by number; all of them He calls by name; because of His great might and because He is strong in power, no one is missing". 70 ... These: Open your eyes and allow yourself to see the creative energy behind the created and learn to appreciate HaShem through looking. Meditate on G-dliness to the extent that you will be able to attain the level of clarity that is comparable to seeing with one's physical eyes.

CONCEPT

Possuk: (Devorim 4:1) ועתה ישראל שמע אל החקים ואל המשפטים אשר אנכי מצוה אתכם לעשות למען תחיו ובאתם וירשתם את הארץ אשר ה' אל קי כי מלמד אתכם לעשות למען תחיו ובאתם וירשתם את הארץ אשר ה' אל קי And now, Yisroel, listen to the statutes and to the judgments which I teach you to do, in order that you may live, and go in and possess the land which HaShem G-d of your forefathers, is giving you".

ועתה ישראל שמע

- "And Now Yisroel listen."

73 through which one regularly interacts with the world and through which one serves HaShem and can come closer to Him. the positive shining through and to understand one thing from another and appreciate that the hand of HaShem is in everything one hears. Also, in Chassidus there is something about hearing which is far superior to seeing because when one sees something they remain detached from that which they see they have observed something going on outside of themselves, whereas when listening, that sounds permeates and reverbs right inside the person listening. 18

Possuk: In Moshe Rabeinu's blessing to the tribe of Levi.
(Devorim 33:10) יורו משפטיך ליעקב ותורתך לישראל שימו קטורה באפר וכל ליל עלי מזבח

They shall teach Your ordinances to Yaakov, and Your Torah to Yisroel; they shall place incense before You and burnt offerings upon Your altar."

Incense before you: Serving HaShem in this way of incense, like offering up incense before HaShem.

CONCEPT

Possuk: When Leah gives birth to her fourth child Yehudah (Bereishis 29:35) וְהָרָה עוֹד וְלָדָה בֶן "And she conceived again and bore a son, and she said, 'This time, I will thank HaShem! Therefore, she named him Yehudah, and then she

The third gate is one's Avodah through his faculty of scent and is as the Possuk says: שִׁמּוֹ 'place incense before You.'⁷⁶ Finally the fourth gate is one's Avodah through his faculty of speech through prayer as the Possuk says: וְעַתָּה פֶּעַם אֶדְבָּרָה 'grasp of G-dliness analogous to hearing. ⁷⁴ Scent: Smell is very spiritual it is there, but you cannot touch it. Although basic vitality for life comes from food but sometimes one needs to draw in deeper, like when one is feeling weak or faint, which can be achieved through smelling, because when you smell something you draw it in deeper within. Because smelling is the essential link between the Neshomoh and the body, which is why it is through smelling that one is awoken from a faint. It is brought down in the Zohar that the scent that one inhales via the nose is the essence of vitality, and there are two levels, which are the two nostrils referred to in the Zohar as the 'Pardashka' of the nose, the right nostril and the left nostril. Also, in smelling itself there are two levels: there is smelling good food, like the smell of the animal sacrifices which is smelled through the right nostril and then there is pure smell like the smell of the Ketores – incense offering particularly the Ketores from Yom Kippur which is pure scent. This pure scent reaches the deepest part of the Neshomoh referred to as 'Yechidah' or the Neshomoh of the Neshomoh and can be reached via smelling through the left nostril. (The left nostril is also more Makif related, associated with Moshiach and Moreh Vadoin, also associated with Teshuvah).. 19

CONCEPT

Stopped bearing: The Ibn Ezra writes: This time I will praise. After having borne four sons. Because Leah was content with this number, she stopped giving birth. Perhaps the message here is about being grateful and giving thanks to HaShem, about admission and being content with what HaShem has given without always asking for more and more.

CONCEPT

This: Being that the body is naturally controlled by one's animal soul and evil inclination, and as mentioned previously one needs to incite his evil inclination by actively placing control measures to wholly commit oneself to HaShem and His ways and to restrict his evil inclination from taking control and coercing him to sin. The method to do this is to place 'judges and enforcement officers' at all his gates of: Sight, Hearing, Smell and Speech.

to ensure not to see the wrong things.

“מ ל דת This time I thank HaShem... and then she stopped bearing”. 79 And the preface to these four must be “You shall set up Judges and enforcement officers for yourself in all your cities” implying that one must restrain oneself in stopped bearing”. 78 Thank HaShem: This is the Avodah of acknowledgement, admission and of gratitude to HaShem via speech alluding to the service of prayer and repentance. The Torah Temimah writes: from the day that Hakodosh Boruch Hu created His world there was no person who praised Hashem until Leah came along and praised Hashem. (With regards to repentance Rabeinu Bachayeh writes: The reason this attribute is part of Yehudah’s name is that he was the first person to publicly retract and confess a mistake he had made when he accused Tamar of being a harlot. He was not ashamed to admit his error, which is the greatest impediment to repentance. According to the Talmud in Sotah (7a) Yehudah’s repentance led to Reuven’s repentance. This is why Dovid Hamelech became one of his descendants. Dovid is reputed to have “been elevated,” i.e. by means of his repentance, in the matter of Bas Sheva (Shemuel II 23,1). Dovid was considered outstanding because he unabashedly repented). 20

Blinker: Only allow one’s own self to look where permitted.

CONCEPT

Musor Seforim: Reishis Chochma writes in Sha’ar Hakedusha (Chapter 8 p159.1) “Everything a person sees etches an image on his mind and when he comes to pray or to study Torah in his mind he will form images based on the images that he has etched into his mind which are a blemish on his mind and they will confuse his mind and he will not be able to focus appropriately. And the eyes that are only able to see from the vitality of the Neshomoh are now using the energy of the Neshomoh to form those forms. The Kav Ha’Yoshor (Chapter 2) Writes: there is an antecedent and a cause that bring a man to gaze at forbidden women. The first cause is the gazing upon impure things until the eye is sated. Although it is permitted to look at the strange creatures from foreign lands, for which the Sages even instituted a blessing, “Blessed is He who diversifies the creatures,” nevertheless, one should not sate the eye with gazing at them but only cast upon them a passing glance. For the eye is comprised of four colors (the white, the dark rim around the iris, the color of the iris and the black of

vision; that one must blinker the eyes from looking at anything untoward. As is explained at length in the Musor Seforim and is also brought in brief from the Rebbe Rashab,⁸⁴ in the the pupil) corresponding to the four letters of the Divine name (Tikkunim 70, 128a). When a man casts his gaze upon impure creatures, he draws upon himself the unclean spirit that hovers over them. This later causes him to gaze upon worse things, which then bring him to sin. 84 Rebbe Rashab: Rabbi Sholom DovBer Schneersohn also known as “the Rebbe Nishmosei Eiden (1860– 1920) fifth Lubavitch Rebbe 18931920. second son of the fourth Chabad Rebbe the Rebbe Maharash. Born in Lubavitch, Russia, interred in Rostov, Russia. Founded the flagship Chabad Yeshivah Tomchei Temimim. Known informally as “Rambam

of Chabad Chassidus" (from his encyclopaedic work on developing Chabad Chassidic philosophy into an organized system), Rebbe Rashab was a prolific writer on Chabad theology. His written works provide the first systematic organization of Chabad thought and provide the basis of these studies in Chabad Yeshivahs today. Much of his work has been published in Hebrew, and some of it has been translated into English, and is available online. Sefer HaMaamorim - Igros Kodesh - Toras Sholom. Kuntres Uma'ayan. Kuntres 21

'Kuntres Hoavoidah'⁸⁵ that even if it is a passing glance HaTefillah. Kuntres HoAvodah. Maamar Heichaltzu. Kuntres Eitz HaChayim. Chanoch Lana'ar. The Rebbe Rashab delivered a series of Chassidic discourses that came under the heading 'Hemshech Ayin Beis 5672' starting in the year 5672 (1911-12). This series of Chassidic essays are considered a fundamental work of Chabad mysticism for its original treatment of many Chassidic concepts. The Ayin Beis series is the longest series of Maamorim from any Chabad Rebbe. This series was written and delivered over the course of several years. In its final form, the series consists of 144 discourses, a number of which were never delivered publicly. The work is also referred to as Hemshech Tehrav from the letters of the number of the year in which it was started. The importance of toiling in one's study is explained at length over there. His teachings also represent the emergence of an emphasis on outreach that later Chabad Rebbes developed into a major theme. 85 Kuntres Hoavoidah: (Chapter 2 pp) the Rebbe RaShaB writes: There are some people who are very distant from actually doing anything bad, bad their hearts are drawn to look and observe, and this observation might be just in passing and feels like it has no effect and he does not get excited, and the only reason why he even looked is because he had pleasure in looking and his pleasure is connected with his essence but even though he did not get excited at what he saw and it was just like a passing sight it still seemingly makes a very big impact and impression on his soul which will not pass before it reveals its ugly inspiration for evil G-d forbid. It then spreads and brings out the deepest of evils may HaShem protect us from all evil.....it is incumbent on a person to be strong on himself and control his faculty of vision and with this he will save his soul for evil and then then his Avodah will be acceptable on high and he will effectuate assistances for his soul and he will ascend higher and higher. 86 Passing glance: At a forbidden matter, without any passion or excitement, this too causes a great blemish. 22

No excitement: He is apathetic towards the seen matter, yet he sees it nonetheless. Even if seemingly, at the time, it appears that what he saw has no apparent negative effect on him, however, despite this, it still has a great effect on his soul.

It won't go by: This forbidden glance will not just disappear, but it will resurface to cause damage.

Block: Pay attention to and be meticulous regarding hearing something that one should not hear. It is said that the structure of the ear is such that one can use the ear itself

CONCEPT

Three people: In Talmud, Tractate Erchin 15B it explains that holding back from Loshon Hora (slander) saves three lives. According to our sages, Loshon Hora kills three people involved, the chatter, the listener and the one it is spoken of. So, by not speaking Loshon Hora one saves three people.

in cool spirit, and there is no excitement at the time, it still makes a strong impression on and great indentation into the soul, and it will not pass by without an overt and negative arousal [thereafter]; G-d forbid. Similarly, one needs to block one's ears from listening to anything negative, like Loshon Hora, through which one can save the lives of three people.⁹⁰ Furthermore, as a result of not hearing Loshon Hora one causes that to block up the ears preventing any sound from entering. 23

But HaShem your G-d, did not want to listen to Balaam. So HaShem, your Gd, transformed the curse into a blessing for you, because HaShem,

Conduct: HaShem's conduct towards us is measure for measure.

One: A human being on this earth.

in the realm above if some will come to prosecute him, then above they won't want to hear Loshon Hora about him either, as the Possuk says: “

ולא־אבה יהוה אלהיך לשמע אל־בלעם ויהפך יהוה אלהיך לך את־הקללה לברכה
כי אהבך יהוה אלהיך

- HaShem does not want to listen”.

Some: If any prosecuting angels come to slander him.

CONCEPT

Possuk: (Devorim 23:6) in regard to the negativity Bil'am spoke: ע ולא־ אבה ה' אל קיך ל ש מ ע
אל־ ב ל עם ו י ה פך ה' אל קיך “ לך את־ ה ק ל לה ל ב ר כה כי א ה בך ה' אל קי

This is because the conduct above operates in a manner of ‘measure for measure’. Therefore, when one does not want to hear anything untoward about his friend,⁹⁶ he causes that when they want to speak negatively about him in the realm above, HaShem does not even listen from the beginning. your G-d, loves you”. ²⁴

Boundary: Control measure.

CONCEPT

Rabbis say: Talmud Tractate Yuma 29 A. 100 Scent: Just like the Talmud says: “The thoughts of doing a sin are harsher than actually doing a sin, and the sign for this is the smell of meat.” Rashi explains: “The smell of roasting meat is a bigger lust than the smell of the meat itself.” i.e. how when one smells something like meat on a barbeque the smell is more fetching than the taste. 101 Needs to be meticulous: Implement damage control measures. 102 One’s speech: There is a Possuk in Mishlei (18:21) מוֹתוֹ חַיִּים בַּיָּד לְשׁוֹן "וְאֵה בִּי יֵא כֹל פֶּרִי

Similarly, there needs to be a boundary set in one’s faculty of scent, meaning that one needs to beware of evil thoughts, as our Rabbis of blessed memory say that the thoughts of doing an Aveira are worse than actually committing the Aveira itself, and the proof is in the ‘Scent’.¹⁰⁰ Similarly, one needs to be meticulous¹⁰¹ with one’s¹⁰² doctors that he needed to drink the milk of a lioness to be cured. Someone volunteered to bring the king fresh lion’s milk; he only asked for ten goats. He took the goats and travelled to where the lions hang out. On the first day, when he was sure that a lioness saw him clearly, he threw her a goat from far away. The next day he came closer... by the tenth day he had won her trust and managed to obtain a full jug of lion’s milk. On his way back, he had a vision; the parts of his body had a major argument. The legs said, "None of the other limbs can compare to us. If we would not have transported the body, it would have been impossible to obtain this milk." The hands argued that they were without parallel. If they hadn’t performed the various actions necessary, it would have been impossible to obtain the milk. The heart argued that if it had not come up with the idea of the goats the ²⁵

speech, as the Rambam writes¹⁰³ “One should not even speak too much with regards to one’s bodily needs ... and as our Rabbis say¹⁰⁴ “I have not found anything better for the body than silence” ¹⁰⁵. But, when one has established these guarding boundaries [and put them] in place, in each of these entire project would have been impossible. The tongue argued that if it had not spoken up, all would have been for naught. All the other limbs were enraged at the tongue, "How do you even dare to make any claim? You are in a dark place hidden away, you can’t do anything and can’t think of anything!" The tongue told them, "You will see, this very day you will all agree that I am your master." After the man heard all this, he went to the king and told him, "Your majesty, here is the bitch’s milk." The king was enraged and demanded that he should be hung. On the way to the execution, all the limbs began to cry. The tongue told them, "Didn’t I tell you that you are all helpless? If I save you, will you all acknowledge my superiority?" They all agreed. The man then asked the executioner to let him speak with

the king once again, and his request was granted. He told the king to try the milk as it would surely cure him, and anyway many people also refer to a lioness as a bitch. The king tried the milk and was cured, and the man was spared. Indeed "Death and life are in the hands of the tongue"! Therefore Dovid HaMelech said (Tehilim 39:2)

אמרתי אשמרה דרכי כי מחטא בלשוני אשמרה לפי " מחסום בעד רשע לנגדי

I said, I will guard my ways from sinning with my tongue; I will guard my mouth as with a muzzle while the wicked man is still before me". (Shochar Tov, 39:2—3, and Yalkut Tehillim, item 721). 103 R

ambam writes: Hilchos Dei'os (2:5) A person shall forever increase in silence, and not speak except for a matter of wisdom or of things which he needs for the sustenance of life in his body. it was said, of Rav, the disciple of our Holy Master, that he never in his life uttered idle talk. Such is the talk of a majority of the people, whereas, even of the necessities of the body man should not multiply words. 104 Rabbis say: Pirkei Avos (Ethics of our Fathers) 1:17. 105 Silence: As in the cliché 'some things are better left unsaid'. 26

four aspects, as the instruction of ‘

שפטים ושטרים תתן לך בכל שערך

- you shall set up judges and enforcement officials for yourself in all your cities'106 through which as mentioned above one achieves ‘

ובעתה רע מקרבך

“Abolish evil from within you107

and through which one achieves...”

ובעתה רע מישראל

Abolish evil from Yisroel”,108 only then can there be 1

“Her Husband is known in the gates”, that Hakodosh Boruch Hu makes Himself known¹⁰⁹ to all, each one¹¹⁰ on his level.

Daled And as a result of following in the directive 106 All your cities: All of one’s four ‘Soul gates’, one’s faculties of Vision, Hearing, Smell and Speech. 107 Within you: Abolishing one’s Evil Inclination and desires which are within him. 108 Yisroel: And then following on to the removal of Evil from all of Yisroel in general as we spoke about before, and then the whole world as the world revolves around the B’nei Yisroel. 109 Makes himself known: HaShem will become grasped, understood, comprehended and envisioned. 110 Each one: Every Jew, on all levels. 27 Dedicated in the merit of

מרת רעכיל צפרה בת מלכה שתחי

for a complete & speedy recovery

y

of“

ש פ טים ו ש ט רים ת תן לך ב כל ש ע רי

111 Yid: As we have understood it to mean according to the teachings of Chassidus, at detail.

112 Possuk: Yishayahu (1:26)

ו א ש י בה ש פ ט יך כ ברא ש נה ו י ע צ יך כ ב ת ח לה א ח רי כן “ י ק רא לך עיר

ה צ דק ק ר יה נ א מ נה

I will restore your judges as at first and your counsellors as in the beginning; afterwards you shall be called City of Righteousness, Faithful City”.

113 Says: regarding the promises of the coming of Moshiach. 114 As it was in the beginning: When Moshiach comes, HaShem will return our Judges and advisors back to how it was when the Temple stood. This phrase is also inserted into the liturgy of our daily, weekday Silent Amida where we ask for Moshiach. Incidentally, when Moshiach comes we will no longer need judges and enforcement officers because there will be no Tumah and therefore no

opposition and therefore no need for enforcement officers, but we will need councillors instead.